12.8 Penney's Game

WORKSHEET

The question

STEP III 2001, Question 13

Read the question before you go on. It is in the STEP Support Programme's question database:

step.maths.org/questions/01-s3-q13

Hints

Try the question on your own first. If you get stuck, read the hints *one at a time*, and go back to the question after each one. Hints marked *Pause and try* are the key steps.

Ask yourself Suppose the tosses so far end in TT and nobody has won yet. Can THH ever appear before TTH?

STAGE 1 States

Ask yourself Neither sequence can be completed in two tosses. After two tosses, what is the next toss's effect from each state?

STAGE 3 *B* against *C*

Ask yourself *C* wants HHT and *B* wants THH. When does *C* win? (Look at what must come just before the first HH.)

Try this next

1. **Four players together.** Try STEP II 2015, Question 12 (step.maths.org/questions/15-s2-q12): Penney's game with four players at once.
2. **Waiting times.** Show that the expected number of tosses until HH first appears is 6, and until HT is 4. (Use first-step analysis.)
3. **The best reply.** For each of the eight sequences of length three, find the sequence that beats it with the greatest probability. Which sequence is beaten most easily?
4. **Conway's formula.** Use Conway's formula to check that HHT beats HTT with probability $\frac{2}{3}$.

Further reading

- **Martin Gardner, *Time Travel and Other Mathematical Bewilderments*** (W. H. Freeman). Includes Penney's game and Conway's formula.
- **Ronald Graham, Donald Knuth & Oren Patashnik, *Concrete Mathematics*** (Addison-Wesley), Section 8.4. Penney's game with generating functions.
- **David Williams, *Probability with Martingales*** (Cambridge University Press). The martingale proof, for later.

The full guided solution, and what the question leads to at university, is in Section 12.8:
https://beyondstep.keithmcnulty.org/ch12/penney.html